

What is Inclusive History?

History is an accumulation of the record of many aspects of life and living. However, most history studies focus on some aspects only. Usually, this is limited to political history. Politics is the official and formal part of state making and not a comprehensive canvas. It focuses mostly on the activities of a small ruling class leaving out the vast majority of people. Such an approach is called “exclusive history” as its vision is exclusively political. Politics is a significant part of history but a part only. Politics is also practiced by the people who control power who are by definition a small group. Thus, it becomes a partial history of a people, a small elite group of people. Through this approach, history study is left incomplete.

Our approach is different because we subscribe to the Inclusive approach to the study of history. This means we look at our past from as many angles as possible to let us study the past of as many people as possible. We do not ignore political history but we look at our past through an inclusive lens to include everyone.

There are many aspects of life that are common to everyone. Some of the key areas are a. Environment and ecology B. Ethnic identity C. Livelihood challenges and responses. D. Social and community structures. E. Faith practices and beliefs. F. Politics and power relationships

The environment – Our life is shaped by our geography, weather, climate, natural phenomenon, etc. We look at how the environment has influenced and continues to influence our life and the creation of history. For example, as a delta, we are washed by floods which have led to the rise of the successful agro- culture. This attracted people as well as invaders from outside Bengal and even outside India to settle and sometimes capture power. So political history was greatly a product of agricultural surplus and an attempt to control it by many.

The person- Who are we and how did we become what we have become. We look at the various ethnic, social, and cultural factors that have led to the identity that we have today. We look at the origin, growth, and flourishing of the people who live in this land and who identify themselves by various names. No group is left out from our gaze and none are looked at in isolation to understand how each has contributed to the making of history.

Livelihood issues – Everyone has to make a living and therefore respond to the challenge and in the process change the world. This is the most universal part of history-making. We live in geography from which we make a living. So the study of livelihood and how this challenge has shaped our lives and our history is about the economics of the majority. We look at the connections between nature and livelihood to identify the key narrative of our life and how people were shaped by the various phases of history. This begins from horticulture to agriculture to capitalism and the rise of industries etc. However, it doesn’t study economic history but how it is linked to social history.

Socio-community history- The people who live here and make a living have a common objective which is to raise a family and flourish as a community. This life has many aspects such as health, homestead, food, festivals, clothes, etc. However, little is known as most of our studies ignore village/community level history or history at the grassroots. We include these micro issues in our study as we want to explore our past in full and not in fragments or a limited manner.

Faith practices - To protect all of the above concerns, human beings practice faith and rituals. Our relationship with such practices is also about developing a world view linked to the challenges of nature, livelihood, ability to participate freely in state-making, etc. Practices and beliefs have also changed over time so we look at all the various stages, levels, and kinds of faith practices and how they are related to our life and world view and its evolution.

Political identities: Finally, the above elements produce attempts to establish political identities and various attempts to establish socio-political control through these identities. These identities include both geographically internal and external groups whether as an ethnic identity such as Aryans, Afghans, British, Pakistanis, etc, or socio-economic constructs such as the Bangladeshi ruling class, etc. We will explore the phenomenon of state making – both governmental and social- and relate it to political power, the role of politics, and how the people outside direct power exercising look upon politics and how they experience it. This includes the rise of alternatives and intermediaries between the states as the government and states as a society.

Our approach is therefore designed to expose the student to a comprehensive look at history which doesn't leave any factors outside. Different players and forces play various roles and together create history. No one is left behind in this approach and it helps the student to understand all the facet and not just political narratives of history.

Inclusive History elements

Some of the key areas of study are:

- Environment and ecology
- Ethnic identity
- Livelihood challenges and responses
- Social and community structures
- Faith practices and beliefs
- Politics and power relationships

Environment and ecology: Bangladesh is part of the Bengal delta, the largest in the world. It has three parts, old, new, and active delta with the Himalayan Mountain that leads to high rainfall. It's flat, warm, muddy, and carries many rivers moving through it to the Bay of Bengal. It's part of the greater rice civilization that extends from China to parts of India. Our geography has influences our history the most.

People: We are a mix of many groups, ethnicities, and races. Nobody is sure of the many elements but some are noticed. We are linked to South East Asia going all the way to Myanmar, Thailand, and perhaps China. Thus we have Mongoloid ethnic roots. We also have Austric/Proto-Austroloid, Negritos, etc mixes that arrived through the North Indian linked routes. The Santal adibasi is a good example of our multiple identity roots. Many including the Aryans, Turko-Afghans came through the North Bengal land routes. We also have other elements and the 50 adibasis of Bangladesh point to a mixed culture over a long period of time. There is no purity of culture, race and language, faith and belief, etc. Understanding our mix is key to the understanding of our history.

Livelihood challenges and responses: Historians say that the fertile mud land has made livelihood easy and it has also drawn migrants from other parts of the region making this a high cultivation zone. That has also led to high migration, high mixing, and high economic surplus that has attracted both people and invaders over time. However, livelihood faced many challenges including natural ones which also led to great coping skills and familiarity with migration.

Social and community structures: The delta agricultural habits have determined community structure as livelihood responses were based on food production. Hence communities formed around food production, fishing, and protection from enemies. Social structures within such settled communities were also influenced by what was most useful and not what was though idealistic. Life was practical and self-protected.

Faith practices and beliefs: Faith practices and beliefs were produced by the same socio-economic reasons generated by the environment and livelihood practices. Thus we note

the prevalence of animist gods and beliefs, nature worship, folk myths, and structures that are common in every culture. Over time as more theological /organized religions came in contact in the last 2000 years or less, they merged with earlier ideas held and formed their own mixes.

Politics and power relationships: Politics and power relationships in a structured form are noticed with the rise of North Indian Aryan rule which influenced North Bengal, the last point of the Aryan empire. Bogra is called Pundra and that is a recognized part of the empire. People beyond this zone were considered Asura or beasts. Aryans and other South and North Indian feudal lords lived and collected taxes from Bengal and ruled over them from the 3/4th century. This was indirectly under the Mauryan and Gupta rule of central India and the first king is considered as Shashankya. Later, the first kingship was established under the Palas – 8th century-supported by the alliance of the feudal lords called Samanta Chakra.

Understanding Inclusive History

Definition · Framework · Six Elements · Examples from Bengal

Part 1 — Defining History: Exclusive vs. Inclusive

Most conventional history studies are built on a narrow foundation — political events, ruling dynasties, wars, and treaties. This approach is now widely recognized as incomplete. To understand why, we must first contrast two fundamentally different ways of studying the past.

1.1 What is Exclusive History? Definition: Exclusive history is a mode of historical study that focuses almost entirely on political events, state formation, and the activities of a small, powerful ruling class. It treats politics as the sole driver of history and leaves out the vast majority of people — the peasants, artisans, women, traders, and indigenous communities — whose lives, labour, and beliefs actually constituted the fabric of everyday existence.

Key characteristics of Exclusive History:

- Narrows the canvas to rulers, generals, dynasties, and formal state-making.
- Treats political power as the primary — often only — force in history.
- Ignores the environment, economy, faith, community, and ethnic identity of ordinary people.
- Produces a 'partial history of a people' dominated by 'a small elite group.' Leaves history incomplete because the majority of people who lived, worked, and shaped culture are rendered invisible.

Why is it a problem?

History written exclusively about power is, at its core, a history of the exception, not the rule. The vast majority of people throughout Bengal's history were farmers, fishermen, weavers, and traders — not kings or generals. Ignoring their lives means ignoring the forces that actually built the delta civilization: rice cultivation, trade, community formation, syncretistic faith, and ecological adaptation. Exclusive history, therefore, does not merely leave gaps; it distorts our entire understanding of who we are and how we came to be.

1.2 What is Inclusive History? Inclusive history is an approach to the study of the past that examines the widest possible range of human experience — from the ecological forces that shaped settlement, to the ethnic origins of the people, their livelihoods, their social organization, their faith practices, and finally their politics. It does not exclude political history but insists that politics alone cannot explain the past. It looks at history through every group's eyes, leaving no community, class, or culture behind.

Key characteristics of Inclusive History:

- Studies the past 'from as many angles as possible to let us study the past of as many people as possible'
- Includes environment and ecology as a primary shaper of human life.

- Examines ethnic, cultural, and social identity beyond the ruling class.
- Treats livelihood — how people made a living — as 'the most universal part of history-making.'
- Explores faith not as official state religion but as a lived, evolving, community-level practice.
- Understands politics not just as what rulers did but how ordinary people experienced power.
- Ensures that 'no one is left behind' and history becomes a complete, democratic picture of the past.

Part 2 — The Six Elements of Inclusive History

Inclusive history organizes the study of the past into six interconnected lenses. Together, these lenses provide a comprehensive view that exclusive political history cannot. The table below summarises each element before each is explored in detail with three examples drawn from the lecture materials.

Element	What it asks us to examine
A. Environment & Ecology	How geography, rivers, climate, and the delta shaped settlement, migration, agriculture, and political power.
B. Ethnic Identity	Who Bengal's people are and how the blending of Mongoloid, Austric, Dravidian, Aryan, and other streams created the mixed Bengali identity.
C. Livelihood	How people made a living — from horticulture to rice farming, maritime trade, and colonial capitalism — and how that shaped society.
D. Social & Community Structures	How communities organized themselves around food production, family, health, festivals, clothing, and homestead at the village level.
E. Faith Practices & Beliefs	How animism, folk religion, Buddhism, Hinduism, and Islam merged over time with livelihood and nature to produce a unique syncretic worldview.
F. Politics & Power	How political identities formed, who ruled Bengal and why, how the ruled experienced power, and how resistance eventually birthed Bangladesh.

A. Environment and Ecology

What it is: The study of how geography, climate, rivers, delta formation, rainfall, and natural events have shaped human settlement, migration, agriculture, economic life, and ultimately political history in Bengal. 'Our geography has influenced our history the most.' (L2 — Inclusive History Elements)

Example 1: The Bengal Delta — World's Largest — as Driver of Migration and Agriculture

Bangladesh sits within the Bengal delta, widely regarded as the largest in the world, with three distinct zones: old, new, and active delta, all fed by Himalayan mountain rainfall. The flat, warm,

muddy floodplain carries dozens of rivers toward the Bay of Bengal. This environment created ideal conditions for intensive rice cultivation — placing Bengal at the heart of a rice civilization stretching from China to parts of India. The abundance of fertile mud drew successive waves of migrants from South East Asia, North India, and Central Asia, making migration and cultural mixing a structural feature of Bengali history from its earliest origins.

Example 2: Monsoon Floods, Agricultural Surplus, and the Attraction of Invaders

As a delta, Bengal is regularly washed by floods that deposit rich alluvial silt across the floodplain, replenishing soil fertility year after year. This natural process gave rise to a remarkably successful agro-culture that produced large surpluses of rice and other crops. The political consequence was direct: agricultural surplus attracted not only settlers but also invaders from outside Bengal and even outside India who sought to capture and tax this wealth. As the L2 lecture notes state, 'political history was greatly a product of agricultural surplus and an attempt to control it by many.' The Aryans, Turko-Afghans, Mughals, and British all came, in different ways, because Bengal was rich — and it was rich because of its environment.

Example 3: The Eastward River Shift and the Mughal Agricultural Revolution

One of the most consequential environmental events in Bengal's history was the tectonic-driven eastward shift of major river courses during the Mughal period. As rivers, including the Meghna moved eastward and flowed into the Bay of Bengal, vast new tracts of alluvial land opened up in eastern Bengal. The Mughals recognized this transformation and organized major agricultural expansion projects — sending entrepreneur-administrators (charismatics) to clear land, build irrigation, and settle communities. This environmental change was directly responsible for Bengal's great agricultural revolution under Mughal rule, the subsequent explosion of wealth, and the social conditions in which Islam began to spread in rural Bengal — demonstrating how ecology drives both economics and cultural change.

B. Ethnic Identity

What it is: The study of who Bengal's people are, where they came from, and how the blending of Mongoloid, Austric-Dravidian, Aryan, and other population streams over thousands of years produced today's mixed Bengali identity. 'There is no purity of culture, race and language, faith and belief, etc. Understanding our mix is key to understanding our history.'

Example 1: Mongoloid-Austric-Dravidian Roots: A Multi-Stream Ethnic Origin

Bengal's people are a product of multiple prehistoric population movements. The earliest identifiable arrivals were Negrito peoples, followed by Austric/Proto-Austroloid and then Dravidian groups. Much later, Mongoloid peoples arrived from South East Asia — through Myanmar, Thailand, and China — via the Brahmaputra valley. The 50 adibasi (indigenous) communities of Bangladesh, including the Santal, are living evidence of this deep ethnic layering. Bengal's identity is therefore 'a mix of many groups, ethnicities, and races' and no single stream can claim to represent the pure Bengali. The Mongoloid ethnic roots connect Bengal to South East Asia as much as to the Indian subcontinent.

Example 2: The Late and Weakened Aryanisation of Bengal

While Aryan culture spread rapidly across North India from the second millennium BC onward, it took over a thousand years to reach Bengal. By the time Aryan influence penetrated through North Bengal — via Pundra (modern Bogra) — it had been diluted by its long march across the subcontinent. This late arrival meant that pre-Aryan cultural, linguistic, and ethnic elements had time to become 'deeply rooted' in Bengal before any external pressure to change them. People beyond the Aryan frontier zone were labelled 'Asura' (demons) by the Aryans, yet this stigma did not erase their cultural distinctiveness. Bengal's ethnic identity thus retained far more non-Aryan depth than any other part of the Indian subcontinent.

Example 3: External Arrivals Through North Bengal: Turko-Afghans and Others

Beyond the prehistoric flows, Bengal continued to receive new ethnic and cultural streams throughout its historical period. The Aryans, and later the Turko-Afghan rulers — including Bakhtiyar Khalji and subsequent Central Asian dynasties — entered Bengal through the North Bengal land routes. Each group added new layers to the Bengali ethnic and cultural mix without fully displacing what came before. This pattern of arrival, adaptation, and absorption is characteristic of Bengal: new groups became Bengali over time rather than transforming Bengal into something else. The 'inclusive lens' requires us to trace all these streams — not only the rulers — to understand who Bengalis are.

C. Livelihood Challenges and Responses

What it is: The study of how people made their living from Bengal's geography — from early horticulture to settled rice agriculture, trade, and colonial capitalism — and how these livelihood challenges shaped social organization, migration, faith, and political resistance. Livelihood is 'the most universal part of history-making.'

Example 1: Fertile Mudlands, High Surplus, and the Dynamics of Migration

The fertile deltaic soil made livelihood comparatively accessible in Bengal, and historians note that this agricultural ease drew migrants from across the region, making Bengal 'a high cultivation zone.' The resulting high economic surplus was the engine of demographic growth, cultural mixing, and political attraction. However, livelihood also faced severe natural challenges — cyclones, floods, and riverbank erosion — that generated 'great coping skills and familiarity with migration'. The capacity to migrate and adapt, born of environmental precariousness, is itself a key feature of Bengali social history that no political narrative alone can explain.

Example 2: From Horticulture to Agriculture to Capitalist Exploitation

The livelihood arc of Bengal's history moves through distinct phases. It begins with pre-agricultural horticulture and shifting cultivation among forest-based communities, transitions to settled rice agriculture as the delta matured, and eventually encounters colonial capitalism when the British

arrived. Each transition reshaped social relationships. The British Permanent Settlement of 1793, for example, converted Bengal's agro-economy into a colonial extractive system by formalizing the zamindari structure, turning peasant farmers into tenant labourers under profit-seeking landlords. This shift in livelihood mode was the direct cause of sustained peasant resistance across the 19th century — making livelihood history inseparable from political history.

Example 3: Nature and Livelihood: The Faith Connection

The connection between livelihood and belief is particularly clear in Bengal. Because nature — monsoon, flood, river, soil — controlled agricultural outcomes, and because agricultural outcomes controlled survival, nature became sacred. 'The land, the river, the weather all became sources of power which deserve worshipping in order to sustain livelihood' (L5 — Faith and Practices). Animist deities, goddess Manasa (protector from snakebite in the fields), goddess Chandi, river goddesses, and later the Sufi pirs who brought new agricultural techniques — all emerged from the nexus of nature and livelihood. Understanding livelihood is therefore the key to understanding faith, community, and social structure in Bengal simultaneously.

D. Social and Community Structures

What it is: The study of how people organized their everyday lives — health, homestead, food, festivals, clothing, family, and community — at the village and grassroots level. 'Most of our studies ignore village/community level history or history at the grassroots.' Inclusive history makes these micro-realities central.

Example 1: Delta Agricultural Habits as the Foundation of Community

In Bengal, community structure was determined bottom-up by the demands of delta agriculture. Because growing rice required collective water management, land clearing, planting, and harvesting, communities naturally formed around food production and fishing, supplemented by collective defence against enemies. As L2 (Inclusive History Elements) states, 'social structures within such settled communities were also influenced by what was most useful and not what was thought idealistic. Life was practical and self-protected.' This practical, livelihood-driven social organization — rather than top-down ideological imposition — was the norm for the overwhelming majority of Bengalis throughout history.

Example 2: The Samanta Chakra: Indigenous Feudal Alliance as Social Order

Before formal dynastic rule, Bengal's social order was structured around the Samanta Chakra — a network of local chieftains and feudal lords who held power across different parts of the delta. This indigenous social structure was distinct from the centralized Aryan or North Indian model. When political chaos — the Matsyanyayam period — disrupted Bengal, it was the Samanta Chakra that produced a consensual solution by elevating the Pala dynasty in the 8th century. This shows that social organization in Bengal had its own logic and its own institutional capacity, independent of external imperial systems. The Samanta Chakra is thus a community structure story, not merely a political one.

Example 3: The Shomaj: Community Formation Around Shrine and Agriculture

One of the most distinctive social structures in Bengal's history emerged during the Mughal agricultural expansion in eastern Bengal. As charismatics (pirs and awliyas) received state land grants to open new agricultural land, they built mosques or shrines as the organizing centres of new communities. The settlement group built around such a shrine was called a shomaj — drawing migrants from western and northern Bengal to clear forests and plant rice. The shomaj fused economic function (agricultural production), social function (community organization), and spiritual function (collective faith practice) into a single institution. It is a perfect example of how livelihood, community, and belief cannot be separated in Bengal's history.

E. Faith Practices and Beliefs

What it is: The study of how Bengal's people developed, changed, and blended their religious and spiritual lives — from animism and nature worship through Tantric Buddhism, popular Hinduism, and syncretic Islam — in direct response to livelihood pressures, ecological realities, and social change. Faith in Bengal is not theology imposed from above; it is survival culture developed from below.

Example 1: Animism and Nature Worship: The Foundational Faith Layer

The oldest and most persistent layer of faith in Bengal is animism — the worship of natural forces such as rivers, the earth, snakes, trees, and the weather. This was the faith of agricultural and fishing communities for whom nature was both provider and destroyer. It produced a rich tradition of nature worship, folk myths, local deities, and ritual practices that were shared across the entire delta population, regardless of caste or later religious affiliation. 'We note the prevalence of animist gods and beliefs, nature worship, folk myths, and structures that are common in every culture.' This foundation never disappeared; later theological traditions simply layered over it.

Example 2: Tantric Buddhism: The Most Rooted Organized Religion of Bengal

Of the three forms of Buddhism that reached Bengal — Hinayana (strict), Mahayana (monastic), and Vajrayana/Tantric (magical and animist-influenced) — it was Tantric Buddhism that took the deepest root. This is because it merged pre-Aryan animist beliefs and supernatural practices with Buddhist philosophy, making it directly relevant to the survival concerns of delta farmers and fishermen. It was not about abstract theology but about 'controlling the uncontrollable using magic and mantra'. The Pala dynasty, Bengal's first great indigenous ruling house, was its most powerful patron — not purely from spiritual conviction but because the vast, land-owning Buddhist monastery network was Bengal's most organized political institution.

Example 3: Syncretistic Islam: A Social Layer, Not a Theological Revolution

Islam spread in rural Bengal not through forced conversion or theological instruction but through agricultural charisma and social admiration. Mughal-era charismatics who organized rice cultivation on newly opened land became revered as pirs and awliyas. Over time, communities adopted aspects

of their culture — calling the mosque a centre of community life, identifying themselves as Muslim — while retaining animist, Hindu-Buddhist practices underneath. 'They called the creator Nirranjan — a Hindu expression — and built their Islamic practice around the mosque and shrine, not the Quran'. The result was a deeply syncretic Bengali Islam that remains distinct from Arabian or Central Asian Islam to this day. Faith in Bengal is always a layered, mixed, and adaptive phenomenon.

F. Politics and Power Relationships

What it is: The study of how political identities formed, how power was exercised and resisted, and how the people outside direct power experienced and responded to state-making. Politics is 'the official and formal part of state making' — important, but only one part of inclusive history.

Example 1: Bengal as Perpetually Governed by Outsiders — And the Logic of Resistance

A defining feature of Bengal's political history is that it was governed almost exclusively by external powers — Aryans, Mauryans, Guptas, Senas (from Karnataka), Turko-Afghans, Mughals, and the British. 'The state system was weak and the dominant peasant society was not part of any inter-state conflict till the British arrived'. This pattern meant that Bengal's political history is best understood not as the story of its rulers but as the story of how its people — overwhelmingly peasants — responded to successive waves of external domination. Resistance, adaptation, and occasional collaboration are the political modes that characterize Bengal's majority, not conquest or empire.

Example 2: The Independent Sultans of Bengal and the Anti-Delhi Alliance

Within the Turko-Afghan period, Bengal produced its own form of political identity distinct from Delhi's imperial control. Dynasties like the Iliyas Shahis (1342–1487) and the Hussain Shahis created genuinely independent Sultanates of Bengal that promoted local Bangla culture, patronized Bengali literature, and opened administration to local people. This was not mere tolerance; it was strategic politics. As L2 (What is Inclusive History) explains, political identities also form in resistance to external powers — and the Bengal Sultans built their legitimacy by distancing themselves from Delhi and aligning with local populations. The title Shah-i-Bangalah (King of Bengal) itself signals a political identity rooted in the land rather than in imperial affiliation.

Example 3: From Peasant Resistance to the Birth of Bangladesh

Inclusive history reveals that Bangladesh did not emerge suddenly in 1971 but is the product of a long arc of political resistance that began with peasant revolts against colonial extraction in the 1760s and matured through language movements, electoral victories, and finally armed liberation. 'Rather than conventional chronology of the rulers of Bangladesh we need to understand its history as a continuity that began much earlier and moved through different stages to become Bangladesh in 1971' (L4 — Socio-Political Profile). The political journey passes through peasant resistance (1760–1857), the creation of the sub-state of East Bengal (1905), the Lahore Resolution (1940), and the 6-point movement — all of which connect to livelihood, ethnic identity, and social structure. Politics, in inclusive history, is always the final expression of deeper forces.

